

The Thunder, Perfect Mind

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Editor's Introduction

Introduced and translated by George W. MacRae

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The title appears to be double: “The Thunder” is not syntactically related to “Perfect Mind” but is separated by a mark of punctuation (:). It is nowhere referred to in the body of the work (unless one should reconstruct “[perfect] mind” at 18,9).

In content Thund. is virtually unique in the Nag Hammadi library and very unusual. It is a revelation discourse by a female figure who is, except possibly for the title, otherwise not specifically identified. The work has no apparent structural divisions but is written throughout in the first person, interweaving and combining three types of statement: self-proclamation in the “I am” style, exhortations to heed the speaker, and reproaches for failures to heed or love, etc. The most distinctive feature is that the self-proclamations are most often antithetical or even paradoxical. The parallelism of form suggests that originally these may have been part of a hymnic structure.

Parallels for this revelatory genre can be adduced from a variety of sources. In Orig. World (II,5) 114,7-15, the heavenly Eve utters a hymnic self-proclamation that is very similar to Thund. 13,19-14,9, and a trace of the same material, though not in the form of self-proclamation, occurs in a similar context in Hyp. Arch. (II,4) 89,14-17. It may be significant that the Thund. passage thus paralleled is not repeated in the work, whereas many of the other self-proclamations occur more than once in Thund., sometimes in varying forms. In such other Nag Hammadi works as Trim. Prot. (XIII,7) and the longer ending of Ap. John (II,7:30,11-31,25), there are examples of the “I style” of proclamation by a revealer figure, but without the antithetical context. There are three interesting parallels to Thund., in content or in style or in both, outside the Nag Hammadi corpus. One is the well-known “Hymn of Christ” in the Acts of John 94-96, in which Christ sings of himself in a succession of antitheses and contrasts, without, however, the use of “I am” formulas. The second example is a passage in the Mandaean Ginza R, Book VI, the so-called “Book of Dinanukht,” which is generally thought to be one of the older sections of the Ginza. There the spirit Ewath recites a formula which contains antitheses similar to, but for the most part not identical with, those in Thund.: “I am death, I am life. I am darkness, I am light. I am error, I am truth, etc.” The third example is a series of passages in ancient Indian literature in which contrasting or contradictory assertions are made of the Deity either in the “I am” form (Bhagavad-Gita IX, 16-19) or in the second or third person (Atharva-Veda X, viii, 27-28; Svetasvatara Upanishad IV,3). These examples include both personal categories (“Thou art woman, Thou art man”) and non-personal ones (“Death am I and deathlessness, What is not and that which is”).

In terms of the religious traditions represented in the Nag Hammadi collection, Thund. is difficult to classify. It contains no distinctively Christian, Jewish, or gnostic allusions and does not seem clearly to presuppose any particular gnostic myth. There are resemblances to the tone and style of the wisdom hymns in the Biblical and intertestamental wisdom literature, and the self-proclamations are similar to the Isis aretology inscriptions. But if the multiple assertions in these works are intended to assert the universality of Isis or of God's wisdom, perhaps the antithetical assertions of Thund. are a way of asserting the totally otherworldly transcendence of the revealer.

(George W. MacRae †)

There has been a tendency among scholars to assume that Thund. is gnostic, in spite of George MacRae's caution, expressed above. Accordingly it has been proposed that the female figure here is to be understood as a combination of the higher and lower Sophia figures found in gnostic literature. It has also been proposed that the figure is Eve, as she is understood in gnostic writings found in the Nag Hammadi collection (see references above) and mentioned elsewhere.

If one takes Thund. at face value and includes the title in consideration, the female figure who is the speaker throughout is named Thunder (feminine in Greek), a figure who must be understood in terms of the parallel phrase in the title: Perfect Mind. Thunder, in Greek myth, in the Hebrew Bible, and elsewhere, comes forth from the highest god (the Greeks sometimes called Zeus "The Thundering One"). It is the way in which the god makes his presence known on earth. In the tractate, Thunder is allegorized as Perfect Mind, meaning the extension of the divine into the world (1,1-2). The understanding of Perfect Mind appears to owe much to the Stoic notion of cosmic Pneuma, the active, intelligent element in all things, made up of air and fire. It was thought of as spanning all worldly divisions and dichotomies and at some level being responsible for everything that occurs. In its manifestation as reason, it was also able to instruct those who listen about the way to true life. (For Thunder's similar role, see 20,26-27; 21,20-32). The tractate as it stands, is not Stoic, since it speaks of a power above Perfect Mind (1,1). But with its conception of the immanence of the divine in all aspects of the world, neither is it gnostic. It still remains "difficult to classify."

(Douglas M. Parrott)